on terror. Besides this, there are other drivers that are likely to shape the contemporary global and regional security environment in the future, such as economic or security blocs, spread of nuclear and other weapons of mass destruction, demographic shifts based on economic or ethnic considerations, and energy, water or other resource needs. Though the US will remain the unchallenged military and economic power for quite some time, the world is slowly moving towards a multipolar configuration. Asia has now assumed a dominant position with the rise of China and India along with the resurgence of Russia, and the presence of Japan. However, at the same time, the security situation in the region is very fragile and unpredictable. It is host to a historical baggage of problems relating to boundaries, religion, ethnicity and resources. The sudden spillover of an internal conflict beyond a country's border cannot be ruled out. This region also has the maximum number of countries possessing 'weapons of mass destruction', with the ever increasing risk of these being exploited by non-state actors. Most significantly, Asia has the epicentre of global terrorism located in the remote mountainous redoubts along the Af-Pak border and jehadi organizations entrenched in the heartland of Pakistan too.

The challenges facing India comprise the entire spectrum, from low-intensity conflict to a conventional war with a nuclear backdrop. On one hand we have internal security threats characterized by insurgency in some parts of the northeast due to geopolitical, tribal, ethnic or other causes, Naxal and left-wing extremism in the underdeveloped and forested areas in the heartland, and a proxy-war in J&K that is aided and abetted by Pakistan. At the other end of the spectrum, there are the conventional challenges that originate from issues such as unresolved borders and sharing of river waters with our neighbours. We are continuing our deliberations at the highest level to find a pragmatic and mutually acceptable solution of our border dispute with China. The border with it extends from the Karakoram, Ladakh, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarkhand to Sikkim and Arunachal Pradesh – a distance of 4056 kilometres. We also have many issues to settle with Pakistan, of which J&K is the foremost. At the same